

THE INFINITE MARKS



AUGUST 9, 2026

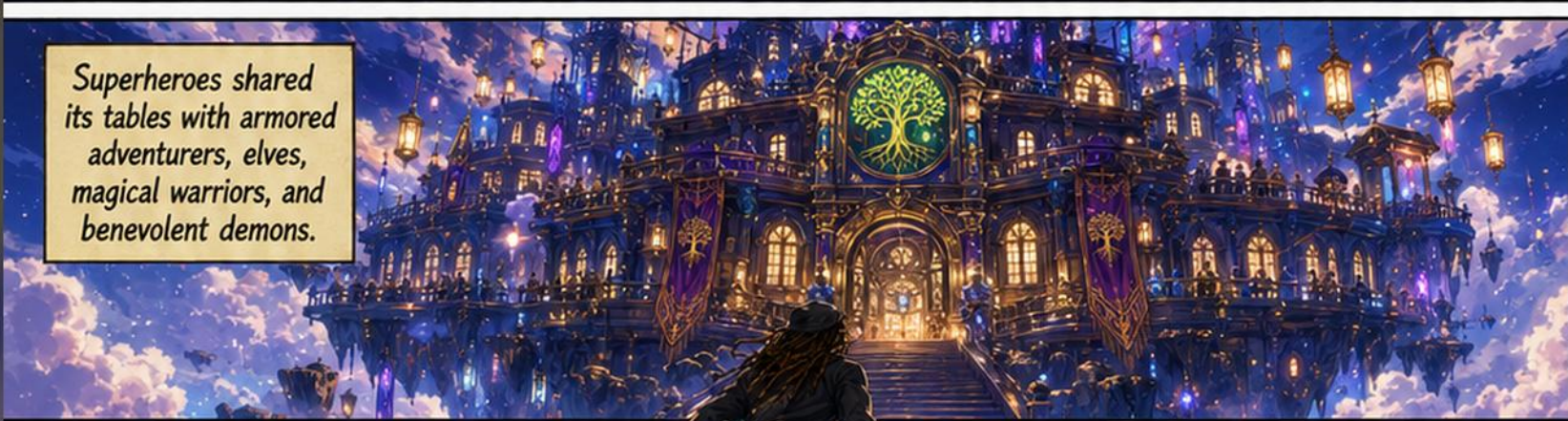
I usually descended toward a city to patrol its streets, but this time I flew higher.



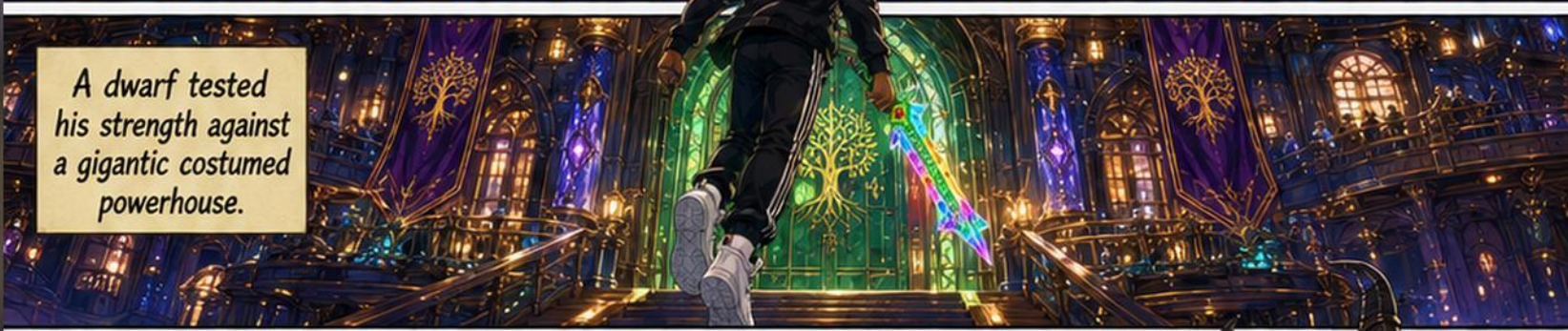
Beyond the clouds, I discovered a gathering place between realms called the Cloud Tavern.



Superheroes shared its tables with armored adventurers, elves, magical warriors, and benevolent demons.



A dwarf tested his strength against a gigantic costumed powerhouse.



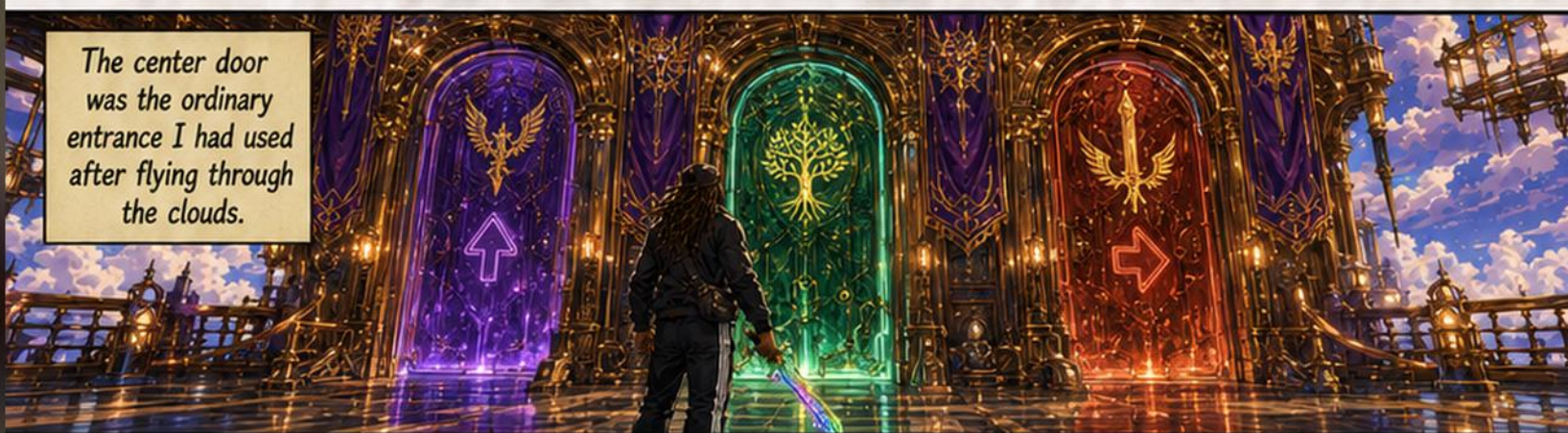
Nearby, a magical superhero studied the terms of a pact beside a demonic guild hero.



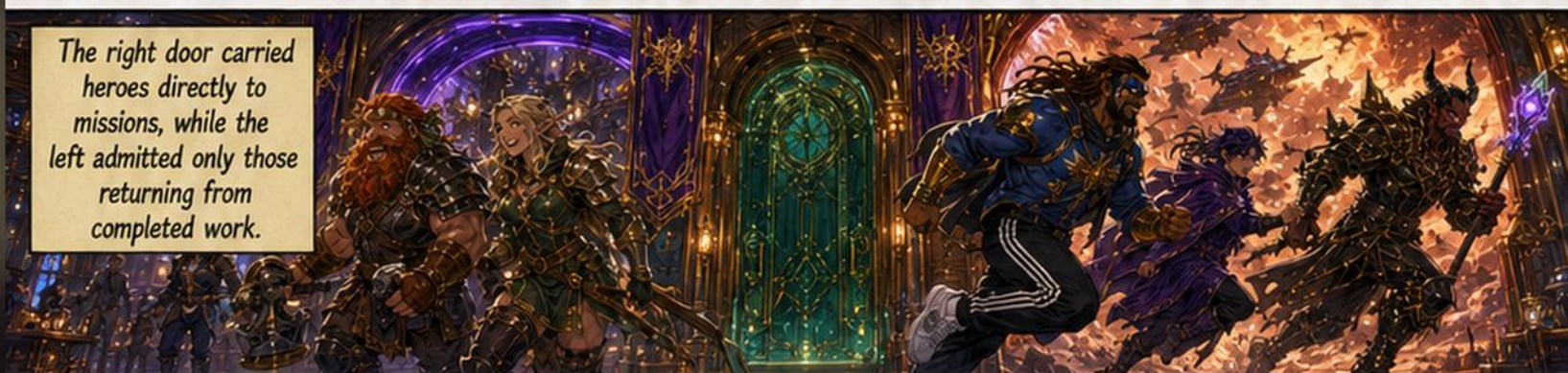
Screens throughout the tavern announced emergencies in distant realms.



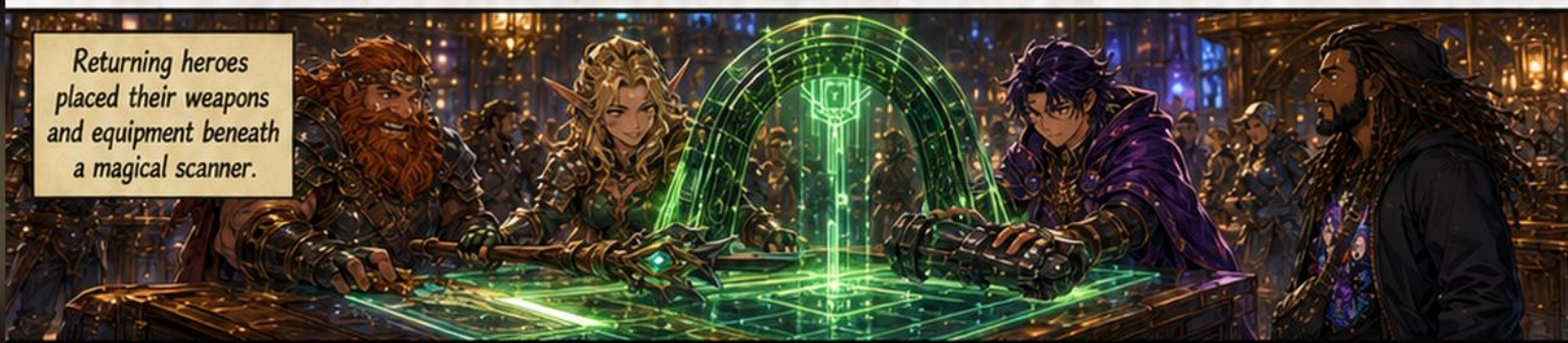
The center door was the ordinary entrance I had used after flying through the clouds.



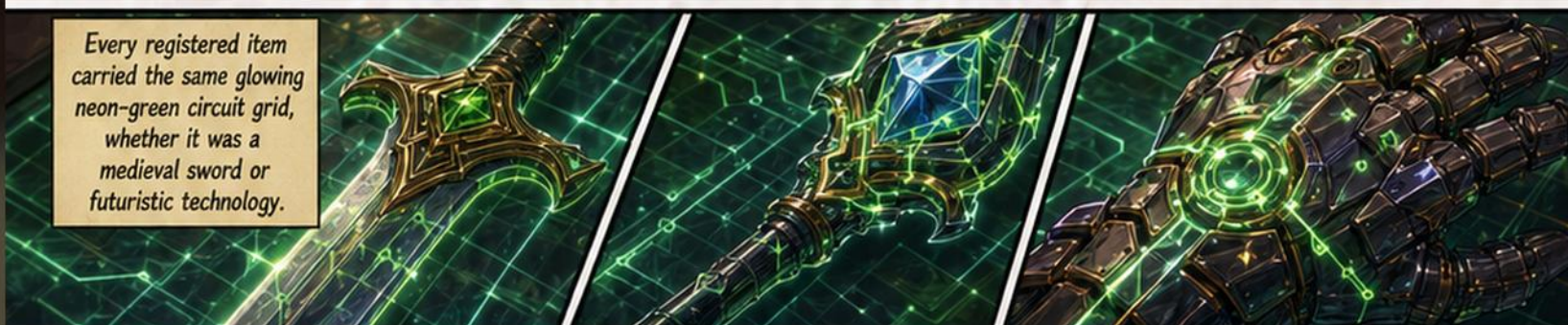
The right door carried heroes directly to missions, while the left admitted only those returning from completed work.



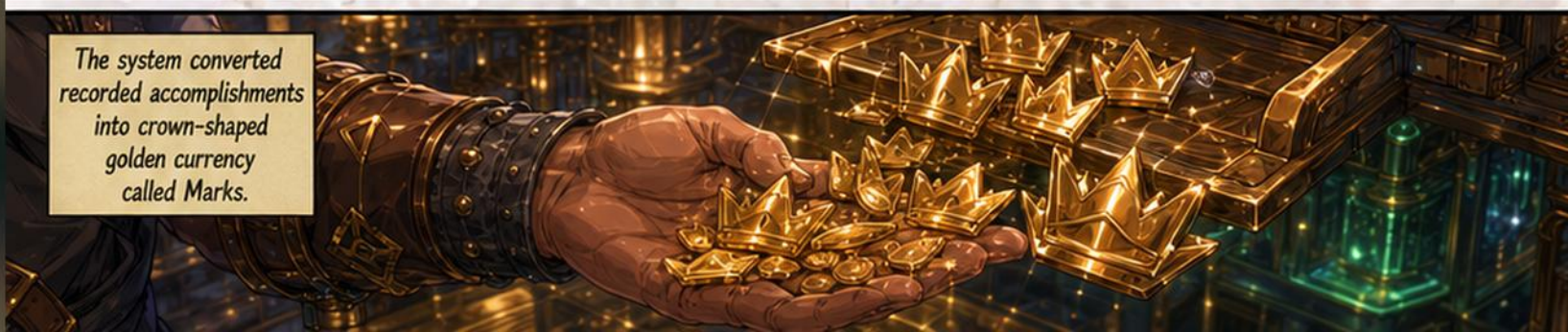
Returning heroes placed their weapons and equipment beneath a magical scanner.



Every registered item carried the same glowing neon-green circuit grid, whether it was a medieval sword or futuristic technology.



The system converted recorded accomplishments into crown-shaped golden currency called Marks.



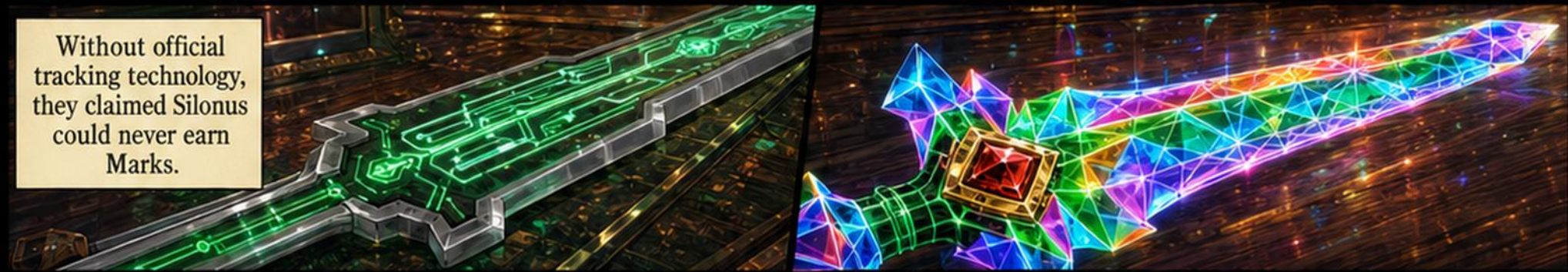
At the bar, an attendant noticed Silonus and dismissed it as unregistered equipment.



They reached for the Rainbow Crystal Life Sword and offered to replace it with a 'real' tavern blade.



Without official tracking technology, they claimed Silonus could never earn Marks.



I immediately rejected the offer and raised a rainbow crystal force field between their hand and my sword.



Silonus was not a worthless blade to surrender for someone else's approval.



The attendant had overlooked that Silonus contained futuristic technology as well as magic.



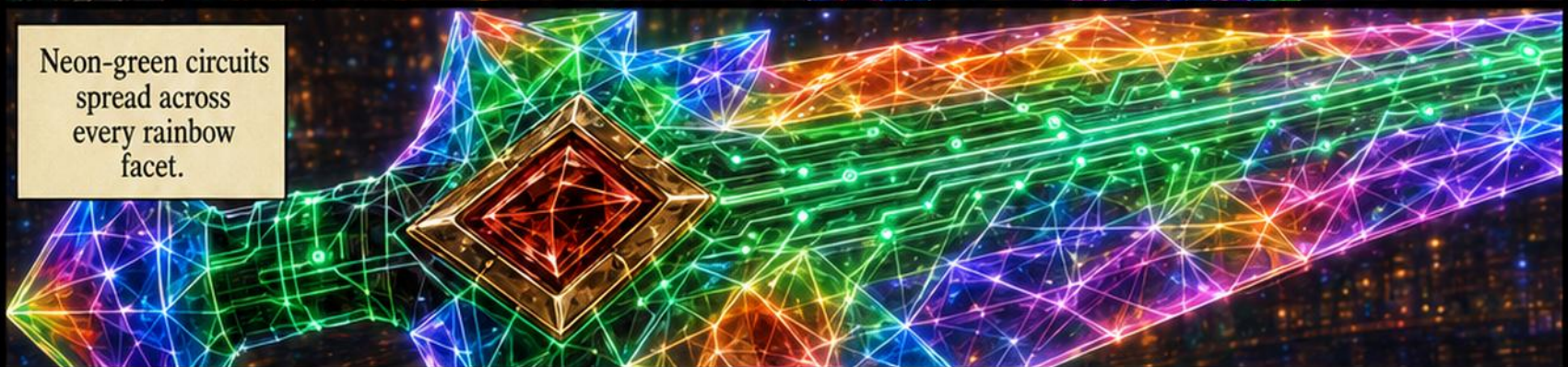
A red gem in its hilt scanned the circuitry running across the tavern sword.



Silonus did not surrender its identity. It adapted the new technology into its own crystal structure.



Neon-green circuits spread across every rainbow facet.



The Life Sword could now speak the Cloud Tavern's language of heroic accomplishment.



The people at the return counter expected a newly upgraded weapon to contain no history.



They did not understand that Silonus had copied more than the ability to count from that moment forward.



It had adapted the system so my previous accomplishments could also be recognized.



Silonus had generated a backlog.



When the scanner read the sword, its display expanded beyond every finite total the tavern could contain.



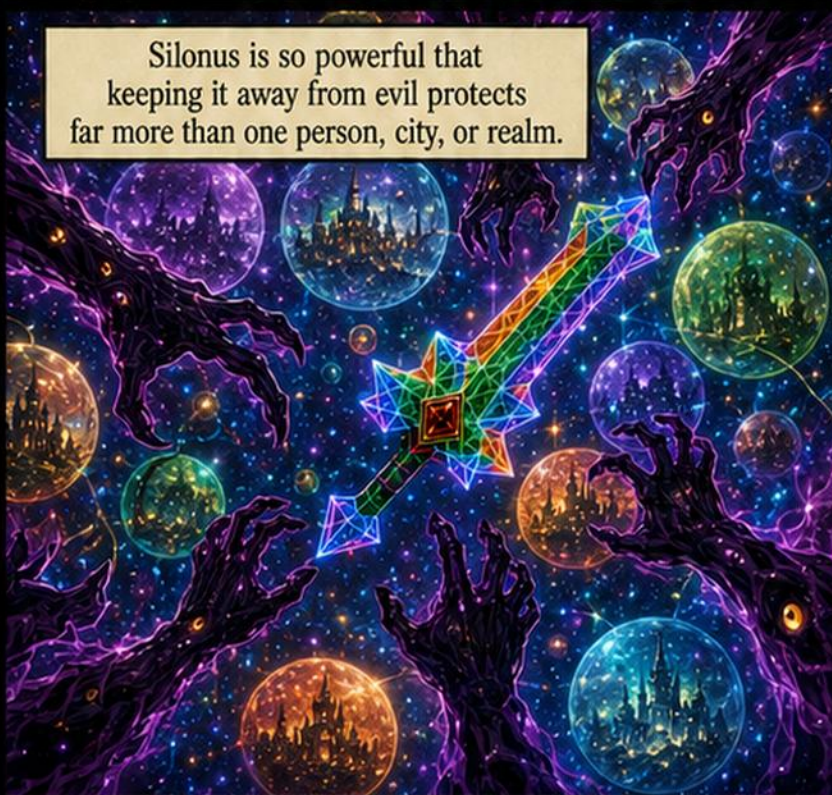
No one believed I could have defeated or captured an infinite number of villains.



They were measuring my accomplishments incorrectly.



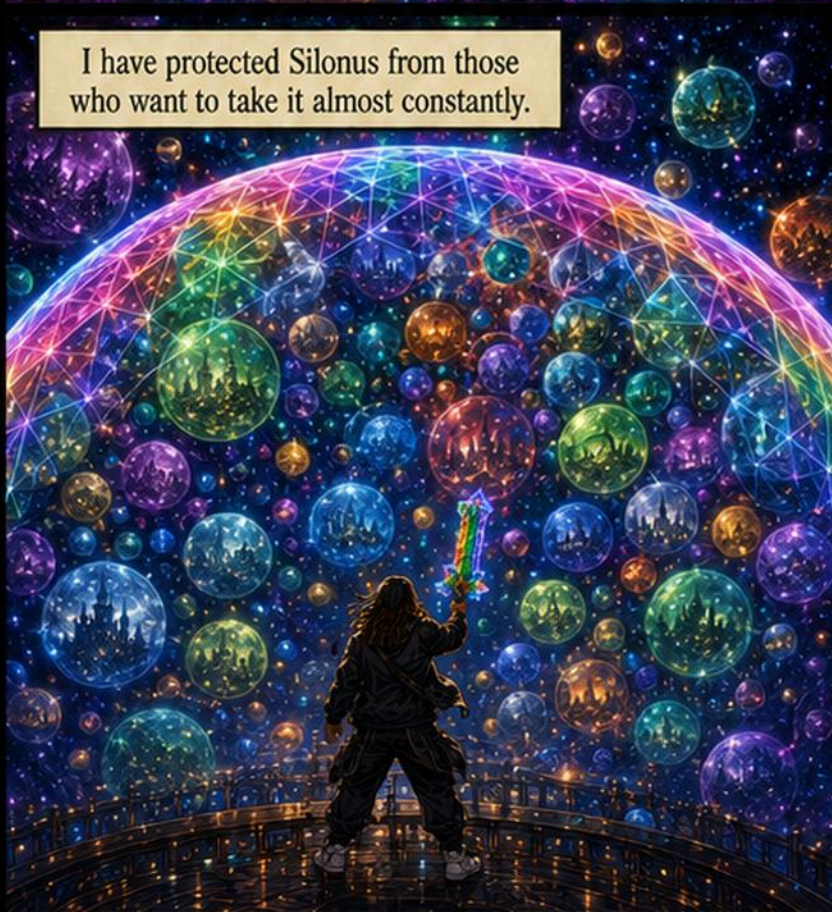
Silonus is so powerful that keeping it away from evil protects far more than one person, city, or realm.



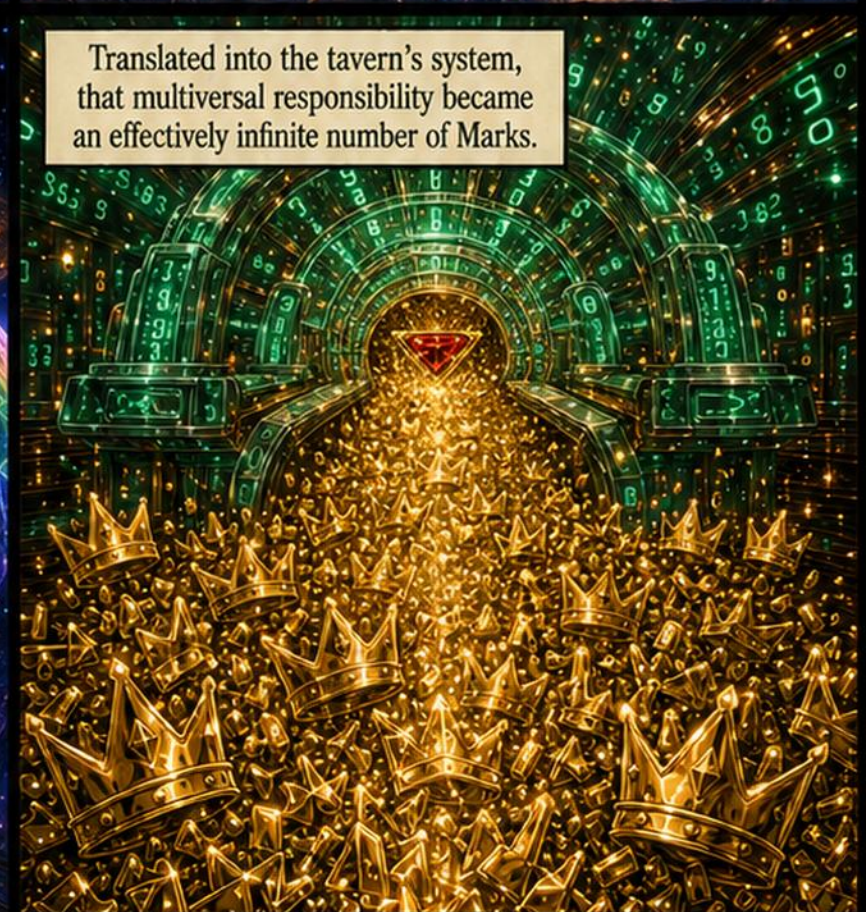
Each time I defend the sword, I potentially defend the entire Storyverse.



I have protected Silonus from those who want to take it almost constantly.



Translated into the tavern's system, that multiversal responsibility became an effectively infinite number of Marks.



My reputation inside the Cloud Tavern changed almost instantly.



I had entered as an unknown newcomer who did not understand its doors, equipment, or currency.



Now its heroes understood that I was anything but inexperienced.



I did not need to exchange Silonus for a weapon the tavern considered real.



The Rainbow Crystal Sword had adapted without becoming anything less than itself—and it carried the record to prove what we had protected together.

